Someone Comes to Mind · Book Three

The One Who Stayed

It goes on even when they do not know

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Before You Start

◆ This Is the Third

Book	What it looks at
One · The One Who Was Already There	What had arrived before I ever asked
Two · The One Who Never Asked	Going toward what will not come back
Three · The One Who Stayed	What continues even when they do not know

You can read this one alone. The three are one line drawn in three parts, so anyone who has read the first two will see more here. Set the three covers side by side and the line joins.

◆ One Thing This Book Does Differently

In the first two books I kept setting out to explain something and stopping. The stopping places are recorded at the end of each chapter.

This is the book where those stopping places gather. So there are fewer answers here than in the first two. What there is instead is the things that do not end. What continues when the other person cannot recognize you, what waits for what is not coming back, what remains after the person is gone.

◆ Every Chapter Ends With a Box

> Someone Comes to Mind

Not something to do. Someone to remember. This book does not tell you to do anything. It points at what has already happened, and that happened to you, not to me. So that box is one I cannot fill.

◆ There Are Three Painful Chapters

The first, the seventh and the tenth. One more than in either of the other books.

To look at what does not end you have to look at what does, and the ending place hurts. **A book that does not hurt is not a warm book.** You may shut it part way. Shutting it is also a way of reading.

◆ And This Book Does Not Finish Either

It is the last chapter of the three and no knot is tied there.

That is not an oversight. In the last chapter I ask one question and write no answer. The question kept rising through all three books, and I have no standing to write the answer, so I write only the question. **The answer is not mine to give, and there is not one line after that chapter.**

◆ How the Facts Are Handled

Each chapter ends with Where This Chapter Came From, holding both what I checked and what I cut because I could not check it. There is almost no outside material here either. Put a number in and the people in this book become statistics. Anything unverified was cut whole rather than softened.

Opening

◆ Opening

Ending is normal. That is the first thing to set down.

What is between people mostly ends. You drift from someone you were close to, you stop seeing someone you saw daily, and a feeling that seemed capable of anything cools in a few years. Nothing is wrong in that and nobody is deficient for it. Ending is the natural direction, and for something not to end, something has to go in.

What this book looks at is the side that does not end. **Places where nothing comes back and nothing stops.**

Someone sits for years beside a person who cannot recognize them. Someone spends a lifetime waiting for what may never come. Someone holds on while hating, and someone still uses the turns of phrase of a

person who is no longer in the world. By the arithmetic it does not explain. The second book spent twelve chapters watching that arithmetic fail and ended one explanation short.

I will not claim to fill that gap here. I cannot. What I can do is gather the things that do not end and set them in one place. Twelve chapters, and one question follows all twelve.

> Every reason to end is present. Why does it not end.

In the last chapter I ask that question once more in a different form. And stop there.

1 · Even When They Do Not Know

◆ In Front of a Face That Does Not Recognize You

You go into the room and the person lying there asks who you are. Somebody who comes every day, met for the first time every day.

The person sitting there takes their hand that day too, tells them what happened that day, combs their hair and goes out, and the next day they hear *who are you* again. There are people who do this for years.

This book starts here, because this is the place that explains least of all, and from the giving side it goes one step further than every chapter of the second

book. Not hearing a thank you and **not having who you are get through** are different things.

◆ A Place With No Receiver

Giving usually has a receiving side. That person knows they received, and knowing, the act is recorded somewhere.

In front of someone who cannot recognize you, none of that is there. What you did today does not accumulate inside them. Yesterday's did not accumulate and tomorrow's will not, and what it is like to do something daily that does not accumulate I do not know, not having done it. Ask people who have and the answers are short.

◆ So Who Is It For

An uncomfortable question comes up here. Who is that act for.

If the receiver does not know, you could say it is for the one doing it. That it is done so as not to regret it later. That feeling is probably mixed in there. Denying it would be false.

That explanation has a place where it does not hold, though. If it were about avoiding regret, the doer would do it better when somebody was watching. They would do less at an hour when nobody was. And that is not how it goes. More of it is done at hours when nobody is watching, and the work of those hours is recorded nowhere, and what is left is an act the receiver does not know about and nobody observes.

◆ Is Nothing Left Inside Them

One thing has to be written carefully.

It does not seem to be true that people who cannot recognize you feel nothing. There are people who do not know a name and grow calmer when that person

comes, people who cannot remember a face and grip back when a hand is taken. Which means memory and feeling do not go together.

Only, this must not be used as comfort. *They still feel all of it* is sometimes harder to hear than anything else, because nobody can confirm it. What cannot be confirmed should not be used as comfort.

◆ What This Chapter Cannot Solve

Something continues even though the receiver does not know. That is a fact. Why it continues this chapter did not find.

Ask the people doing it and mostly they say they just go. It is not that they are withholding an explanation; they seem not to have one. An act with no explanation continuing for years is the first riddle of this book. The eleventh chapter looks at it once more.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Is there someone you still remember who does not remember you. If there is, they came to mind just now. If there is not, you might think instead about who would remember you that way.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

That people losing their memory can feel a person without knowing the name is something I was told by people who have nursed them. It is hearsay and not something I verified. It is written as such.

I know there is research in this direction. I saw in public sources that emotional memory persists separately, and I could not read the material properly, so it is not in the text. Summarizing what you have not read produces errors. That was the thing I most wanted in this chapter, and it is not here.

2 · The Same Thing Every Day

◆ What Gets Recorded as an Event

Stories about saving people mostly get recorded as events. Pulled a child out of the water. Drove through the night to get there.

Those happen once, and happening once, they make a story. A beginning, an end, tension in the middle. People like those stories.

And what actually keeps a person alive is usually not that. It is the side that did the same thing several thousand times. This side does not make a story. No beginning, no end, no tension, and what was done yesterday is identical to what was done today.

◆ Why Repetition Is Invisible

There is a reason repetition goes unseen. **What stays the same does not catch the eye.**

The human eye watches what changes. What does not change becomes as good as absent. So the person who cooked every day is invisible and the one day they did not is visible, and the person who handed over the pills every day is invisible and the one day they forgot is visible.

Because of this, the repeating side never once gets noticed for doing well and gets noticed only for doing badly, and do it several thousand times, miss once, and the once becomes their record. It is an unjust accounting and it cannot be changed, because that is how eyes are built.

◆ Inside the Person Doing It

Leaving aside what is invisible from outside, I looked at what happens inside the one doing it.

At first they do it on will. Then they do it on habit. Then comes the strange part, where at some point the act stops being their routine and becomes them. Not doing it feels like not being themselves. People who have reached that stage have a harder time when they stop.

That seems to be why the carer sometimes collapses after the cared-for person has gone. It is not that they have nothing to do. It is that they have gone. The seventh chapter looks at that place.

◆ How Repetition Accumulates

The tenth chapter of the second book said a small thing repeated tens of thousands of times stacks up. One thing can be added here. **The stacking is invisible from the receiving side too.**

A child does not know what they were given daily. They do not know when they are grown. They find out on the day they end up raising a child and doing

the same things. So the value of this work is made known one generation late, and by the time it is known the person who could have been told is old, or gone.

◆ The Word Tedious

Here is where this chapter is stuck.

Writing only well of repetition does a disservice to the people doing it. The work is tedious. Saying so sounds like a shortage of love, so they do not say it, and the tedium and the love are both there at once.

Then what to call the state of being bored and continuing anyway I do not know. Call it endurance and it goes cold. Call it love and the tedium drops out, and there does not seem to be a word in the language with both in it, and I am not going to invent one.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone did the same thing for you several thousand times. Think about what it was and it will probably be something extremely trivial. Trivial is correct.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. Observation and things I was told.

What happens to a carer after the person they cared for is gone has been studied. I did not use it. Bring that material in and the chapter becomes an explanation of a named syndrome, and then those people become case studies, and that the material exists is worth recording.

3 · The Waiting Chair

◆ While Waiting You Appear to Be Doing Nothing

There are chairs in a corridor. The person sitting in one is doing nothing. That is how it looks from outside.

Outside an operating room, outside an emergency department, outside an examination room, in an arrivals hall. The person sitting there is holding nothing and has nothing to do. They are there for hours. Asked to write down what they did in that time, there is nothing to write.

And that time is the longest time that person has. And anyone who has sat in that chair **knows that sitting there is the work.**

◆ The Waiting Side Has No Power

Waiting has one property. The one waiting can do nothing.

Inside the operating room other people are working. The waiting side cannot get into that work, cannot make it go better, cannot make it end sooner. There is exactly one thing available to them. Being in that place.

That looks like nothing and it is not, and when it is over and the other comes out, it matters enormously whether anyone was in that chair, and the one coming out remembers it for the rest of their life. One thing happened in those hours, and the one thing lasts for decades.

◆ Waiting for What May Not Come

There is a longer kind of waiting. The kind with no fixed day on which it ends.

Waiting for someone who left to come back is like that. Waiting for a child who stopped answering. Waiting for someone whose fate is unknown. This kind is not hours but decades. And unlike the operating room, there is no door. With no door to open, it does not end.

Look at people in that position and the waiting has become their life. They eat and work and laugh, and underneath it the waiting is laid down. A phone rings and the thought comes once. Decades on, it still comes once.

◆ Is Waiting Love

Something catches here. Whether it is right to call waiting love.

Waiting can have holding-on mixed into it. Being unable to let go and loving look the same from outside. Wait for someone who does not want to

come back and the waiting becomes a burden on them. So waiting is not always good.

I have thought about where the two divide. One thing occurred to me. **Whether the waiting side presents the waiting as a bill.** Say *I waited this long* and it is an invoice. Wait and say nothing and it is not.

That line is not clean either. There are cases where the other person knows without being told, and knowing is also a weight. I cannot draw it.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Was there someone sitting there when you came out of somewhere. You do not know how many hours they sat. You may remember that there was nothing in their hands.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

The corridor in this chapter is a general scene and not a particular place.

There is material on families waiting for relatives who went missing. I did not use it. Using their waiting to make the argument of this chapter would turn that waiting into my raw material. I decided against it.

4 · The Side That Does Not Come Back

◆ Only One Side Is Left

What is between people has two sides, and one day only one side is left.

There is a side that stopped answering and a side that keeps sending, and a side that does not call at the holiday and a side that calls anyway. A side that left the house and a side that leaves the door unlocked, and from one side that relationship is over, and from the other it is not.

This chapter stands on the side where it is not.

◆ There Are Reasons For Not Coming Back

Let me not write badly of the side that does not come back. That would ruin the chapter.

There are usually reasons. Somebody was hurt in that house. Somebody knows that going back means being hurt again, and for some people distance is the only way of keeping themselves intact, and telling them to go back does harm.

So this is not a chapter telling anyone to come back. It looks only at **what happens on the waiting side**, with the not-coming-back side left alone.

◆ The Sending Side's Years

Watch people who keep sending to someone who does not answer and they pass through several stages.

First comes anger. Then comes looking for the reason. What did I do wrong, was it that thing. After a few years they stop looking for the reason. And

then comes the odd place, where **the anger drops out and only the sending is left.**

People who have reached that stage use similar sentences. They say they send even though it is not answered. They say they do not even expect a reply. And they send every time. How it works to send while expecting nothing I cannot explain.

◆ They Do Not Declare an End

One observation to record. Those people **never declare an end.**

They do not say that is enough, no more. Perhaps because they know saying it is what makes it stop. Perhaps because the sentence simply will not come out of their mouth. Without the declaration the relationship stays open. It stays open with nothing passing through it, for decades.

So if the other side comes back one day, the place is still there. The one coming back is startled by that. The place is sitting there as though nothing happened in the meantime. Nothing did not happen. Someone kept that place empty for decades.

◆ And If They Do Not Come Back

Here is the stuck place. Not coming back is the more common case.

Often the one waiting goes first. Then the waiting ends unused. Nothing happened and nobody knows. What to call those decades I do not know.

I would like to write that it was not wasted, and I do not have standing to write it. I was not the one waiting, and if the person who did the waiting says it, it is their sentence; written by me, it is a performance of comfort. So that sentence is out and the chapter stands without it.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Is there someone you do not contact. They may still be keeping your place empty. I will not tell you to go back. If you have your reasons not to, those reasons are right too.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. Observation and things I was told, with no names, because they were about families.

There is material on why distance from family is sometimes necessary. I started reading further in that direction and cut it as outside the scope of this chapter. That it exists is worth recording, because some readers will finish this chapter feeling they got it wrong. They did not.

5 · Hating, and Still

◆ Both Are There Together

We are taught that love and hatred are opposites. Live a while and the two are inside the same person together. Together on the same day.

The person you hate most is often the person closest to you. There is no occasion to hate a stranger. Hatred requires nearness. So a place with a lot of hatred in it is also a place that had a lot of love.

That is what this chapter is looking at. **Hatred is not love gone cold. It only grows where there is love.**

◆ They Cannot Bear Hating

Come to hate someone close and a person hurts twice. They hurt from the hatred, and they hurt again

from being someone who hates.

That is why people who hate a parent find it so hard to say. Say it and you are a bad child; do not say it and you carry it alone. So sometimes a person suddenly starts being dutiful in ways they never were. They are trying to cover the hatred. Covered, it does not go.

And when that person falls ill they go running. They go running while hating. How two such things live inside one person they cannot explain either.

◆ Not Cutting It Off Despite the Hatred

One shape of the thing this book calls not ending sits right here.

There are reasons to cut it off and they do not cut it off, and there is hatred, there is injury, they know it would be easier not to see them and they know nobody would blame them, and they do not cut it

off, and they go again at the holiday. They go and they fight again. And they go again.

You could call that foolishness. If it were foolishness they would stop after one try, and they do it for decades. Foolishness does not last decades. Something else is holding it up.

◆ Some Things Must Be Cut Off

Something has to be written here without fail. **Some relationships must be cut off.**

Where there is violence, where someone keeps being injured, where the other party has no intention of changing. Call not cutting off in a place like that love and the sentence kills people. This chapter is not about places like that.

There is a clear line between not cutting off as love and not cutting off as self-harm. Only, that line cannot be drawn from outside. Only the person

standing there can know, and sometimes they only know much later. I cannot draw it.

◆ Writing the Hatred Down

One useful thing to set down. Admitting there is hatred looks better than trying to remove it.

Try to remove it and the hatred hides. Hidden, it comes out somewhere else. You get angry about unrelated things and it lands on the wrong people. Admit it and it stays where it is. Hatred that stays in place can be looked at, and looked at, what is underneath it becomes visible too.

Underneath it there is usually something that was hoped for. It is hateful because what was hoped for did not come. With nothing hoped for there is no hatred either.

◆ Is Hatred Evidence of Love Then

Here is the stuck place. Go that far and it goes too far.

That there was love where there is hatred looks right, and turn it around and say the measure of the hatred is the measure of the love and it is wrong. Written that way it makes hatred into a good thing and ends up defending people who injure others, and the two sentences look joined and joining them is dangerous, so I am leaving them apart.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Among the people you hate, is there one you have not cut off. I will not ask why not. It would be good if you knew the single fact that you did not.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. Observation and things I was told.

There is a term in psychology for holding two feelings about someone close at once, and I confirmed from public sources that the term exists and did not use it. Attach a term and the state becomes a symptom, and this chapter is not looking at symptoms.

There is material on relationships that must be cut off, some of it good. Outside the scope of this book, so it is not used. Anyone who needs that would do better to look there than to read this.

6 · I Never Gave Up

◆ They Nearly All Say the Same Sentence

Ask people who have held on to someone for a long time and a similar sentence comes out. They say they never gave up.

Watch how the sentence arrives and something is odd in it. It does not mean they never thought about giving up. Mostly they thought about it repeatedly. Ask them to count the days they wanted to stop and they can count them. And they still say they never gave up.

So the sentence is not about a state of mind. **It is about the fact that they never once stopped.**

◆ Wanting to Stop and Stopping

These are two different things. Mix them up and you start cutting yourself down unfairly.

Somebody who goes every day thinks, on the way, that they do not want to go today. They think it and they go. That person went. That they did not want to is not in the record and only the going is. On the receiving side, that is a person who came gladly every day.

And on the doing side, all those days of not wanting to are remembered. So they conclude their love was insufficient. That is the saddest thing in this chapter. **The day you went without wanting to is heavier than the day you wanted to go.**

◆ Giving Up Does Not Arrive in a Day

Watch the shape of giving up and it does not come at once. It thins out and one day it is gone.

Weekly becomes monthly, monthly becomes holidays only, and then they stop going. Almost nobody decided on a day to stop. They drift without a decision. Which is why, asked when they stopped, they cannot answer.

Not ending has the same shape. Almost nobody decided to keep going either. They simply go again next week. **Neither the ending side nor the continuing side is made of a decision. Both are made of one next week.**

◆ So What Makes the Next Week

A thing worth knowing appears here. What is the difference between the side that goes again next week and the side that does not.

It is hard to call it the quantity of love. The ones who stopped going did not love less. They ran out of strength, and I am in no position to reproach them.

Look at circumstances and a little of the difference shows. People carrying it alone hit bottom fast. People sharing it last. Near is longer and far is shorter. Money makes it longer and no money makes it shorter. **Lasting has more to do with circumstance than with love.** That is a deflating conclusion and it looks true.

◆ The Cases That Go Past Circumstance

And there are people whose circumstances are as bad as they get who go all the way. Alone, far, no money, and they did it for decades.

Look at them and the explanation above does not hold. So it has to be corrected, and corrected, the other side stops holding. Explain by circumstance and those people are unexplained. Explain by love and the people who ran out of strength become deficient.

Neither works, so both are written down and not made into one. Make them one and somebody gets cut down. The chapter stops here.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone never gave up on you. They too will have had days when they wanted to stop. You do not know those days, and without your knowing them, they came.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. Observation and things I was told, and the passage about circumstances is my own inference, marked as such.

There is probably research on the conditions under which long-term care continues. Finding it would have made this chapter sturdier and I did not look.

Find it and the chapter becomes four conditions for lasting, and then anyone who is not on that list starts doubting their own part, and that was the thing I most wanted to avoid here.

7 · After That Person Is Gone

◆ Gone and Not Gone

When a person goes you would expect what they did to go with them, and it does not. Several things stay.

The strangest of them is **speech**. One day you notice that what came out of your own mouth is theirs. You were not a person who said that, and you are saying it. There is no memory of learning it and it is in there.

Habits stay too. The order you cook things in, the way you close a door, what you do first when somebody says they are ill. What that person did for decades you are doing now.

◆ Belongings Do Not Stay for Their Use

Objects stay as well, and objects are a little different.

The valuable things among someone's belongings mostly get dealt with. What stays is the things with no value. The glasses they wore, a bowl worn where their hand went, one sheet of paper with their handwriting. Those cannot be thrown away. Being useless and unthrowable is what a keepsake is.

Thinking about why, it seems to be because that person's body touched the object. The place their hand went is still there. The worn patch on that bowl was made by their hand, and it cannot be made again.

◆ What Continues on the Remaining Side

This book is about what does not end. Here is the clearest instance of it. One side is gone and something continues.

The nature of it is different, though. In the earlier chapters the giving side kept going. Here the giving side is absent and the received thing keeps going. It is

not that they stopped. It is that they are not here and it did not stop.

Which is why people do things for someone who is gone. Visiting a grave. Buying what that person liked. Doing something for a receiver who is not there. The second book spent twelve chapters on going where nothing comes back, and here there is not even anyone to receive.

◆ Time Heals Is Half True

One thing I will state plainly. *Time heals* is half true.

The sharp parts round off. They do not disappear. Decades later a smell or a song brings it back whole. That is not a malfunction; it is because the person was there. What passes leaving no mark was never deep in the first place.

So saying it will be all right to someone for whom it is not yet is something to be careful with, and the

sentence is heard as *hurry up and be all right.* I have decided not to use it.

◆ Where Did They Go

What this chapter cannot solve is here.

What remains plainly remains. There is a turn of phrase, a habit, a bowl. And that is the trace they left, and it is not them. Where did they go. That is not a question this book can answer.

I stop here. Pretend to answer what cannot be answered and every other chapter in this book becomes false along with it, and what can be recorded is that the question kept rising through all three books. It comes up once more in the twelfth chapter.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

There is a phrase you use that is not yours. If whose it is comes to you, that person is still speaking inside you.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. Observation and things I was told.

There is a great deal of material on how grief moves, some of it good. I did not use it. Set out the stages and a reader starts counting which stage they are in, and then they are grading their own grief. Better left out, I thought.

Whether there is research on being unable to throw away a keepsake I did not look for.

8 · It Goes to the Next Person

◆ With Nowhere to Repay, It Goes Sideways

The last pages of the first book said what we receive goes sideways. This chapter looks at the going.

Try to repay and the road is usually blocked. The giver is gone, or far away, or will not take it, or has already died. Hold something unrepayable in your hands and a person sends it somewhere. The direction is always the same. **Never upward. Sideways or down.**

◆ It Goes in the Shape It Arrived

This is the clearest thing in the chapter. What was received goes to the next person in the shape it came in.

Someone carried on a back carries someone. Someone who had a person to feed them feeds people. Someone who had a visitor when they were ill goes when someone is ill. They do it the way it was done to them. Other ways do not work well. They learned one.

So watch the shape of a person's giving and you can see the shape of what they received. Not what they give. How. The one who gives by food, the one who gives by money, the one who gives by talking, the one who gives by sitting quietly are all different from one another. What each of them received was different.

◆ The Bad Parts Travel the Same Way

Writing only one side would be false. If it goes in the shape it came in, **the bad parts go in that shape too.**

Someone who was hit comes to hit. Someone raised on comparison comes to compare. One day you

catch yourself saying with your own mouth the sentence you hated most. That is the frightening part of this structure.

Flowing allows no selection. You cannot keep only the good. So to avoid sending on what you received you have to put force in the middle. Some people do. They have decided which of the things they received they will not send on, and they live that way, and it does not happen by itself and it takes a lifetime.

◆ Cutting Something Off Is Also Passing Something On

One thing to set down. Cutting off a bad thing is also an act that reaches the next person.

Someone was hit and did not hit. That person's child grows up unhit. That child does not know what they did not receive. **What was not received is invisible.** So the act is known to nobody, and the person gets no credit for it as long as they live.

This looks like the most invisible giving in the book. Not giving by doing something, but **giving by not doing it.** An act of omission cannot be recorded.

◆ And People Who Received Little

The place where the second book jammed comes up again here.

If what we received is what travels, someone who received little should have little to send. And there are people who did not. People who received almost nothing and give a great deal. Flowing does not explain them.

The second book built two explanations and discarded both. I tried to build one more here and it fails again. The ninth chapter looks at those people from a slightly different angle, and no explanation there either, only the record that there are people giving without knowing where theirs came from.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

There is one way you are good to people. Think about who did that to you. If it comes to you, that is the person.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. Observation and things I was told.

There is a great deal of research on bad things being handed down across generations. I confirmed from public sources that the field exists and put no figures in the text. Put a figure in and it reads as *people from houses like that turn out this way.* The people who did not are the back half of this chapter. I did not want to make them the exception, so the numbers came out.

9 · It Skips a Generation

◆ A Square Skipped

The last chapter said what we receive goes sideways or down. And it often jumps a square.

What came from a grandmother does not pass through the mother to the grandchild; it goes from the grandmother straight to the grandchild, and the mother in between may not have received much of it. Someone strict with their own child is different with a grandchild. Same person, different.

Why the skipping happens is what this chapter looks at.

◆ The Raising Place and the Not-Raising Place

One part is circumstance. A parent has to raise the child and a grandparent does not.

The raising side has to teach, and they have to say no to what must not be done, they have to feed, they have to get them to school. The person doing that work takes the dislike. Raising has dislike built into it.

The not-raising side does none of that work. So they can give and only give. The same person becoming a different person with a grandchild is not a change of character. It is **a change of position.** Position makes people like that.

◆ And Not Only Circumstance

Circumstance does not account for all of it. There is one more thing.

Grandparents know what they failed to do when raising their own children. They know it was because

they were busy staying alive. What they failed to do is still in them, and they do it for the grandchild, and the thing being done for the grandchild is in fact the thing they meant to do for their own child.

So the middle generation watching this feels complicated. The thought *they never did that for me* is available, and that thought is not wrong either. And through that act the parent is doing something late. Both are true, so it will not tidy up in either direction.

◆ What Skips Travels Two Squares

Something interesting shows from this angle. The love that skipped lasts longer.

To a grandchild, a grandmother is someone who almost never scolded them. So the memory stays clean. Decades later, when that grandchild is good to somebody, they use that shape. One block of

something received with no condition on it is something a person draws on for a lifetime.

Twice already it has been written that some people who received little give a great deal. Ask those people and one person turns up surprisingly often. Not a parent. One person. A grandmother, an aunt, a teacher, a woman next door. One seems to be enough.

◆ Is One Enough

Here is what this chapter cannot solve. The sentence *one is enough* is hard to write as it stands.

I want to write it. It is hopeful and I have seen such people. And writing it closes the road on anyone who had none. There are people who had none. For them this chapter is useless.

And one more thing. There will be cases where there was one and it did not work out, and the people I

met were the ones it worked out for, which is probably why it looks this way to me. The ones it did not work out for do not tell this kind of story. So what I have seen is not all of it. Knowing that while writing is different from not knowing it, so it is recorded.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Is there someone other than a parent who was good to you with no condition on it. If one person came to mind, you might say their name once, to yourself.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. Observation and things I was told, with inference marked as inference.

There is research, as far as I know, on what one person outside the family does for a child. I

confirmed from public sources that the field exists and did not bring it into the text. Prop up the sentence *one is enough* with a source and the sentence becomes a conclusion, and I wrote inside this chapter that I cannot use it as one.

That the people I met are a skewed sample is stated in the text. That is the most honest line in the chapter.

10 · The Last One Left

◆ The Number Goes Down

When a person is very ill or very old, the number of people around them goes down. There is almost no exception to this.

At first many come. Word gets out and the phone rings and people arrive. After a few months it thins. After a few years it is very few. It is not that they are bad people. People have their own lives, and a long illness is not something the circle can keep pace with.

And at the end there is usually one person left. Two at most.

◆ Who Stays Is Not Predictable

Look at who stays and it is not what you would expect.

You would think it would be whoever was closest. It is not. It is not the one who talked most either. Quite often it is somebody who was not especially noticeable. From around them comes the sentence that they never thought that person would go that far.

Why that person they cannot explain either. They say it just ended up being them. They say they did it because nobody else was. **The one who stays is not the one who chose to. It is the one who did not leave.**

◆ What Happens to the One Who Stays

Look at what happens on the side of the one who stayed.

First the outside world shrinks. They cannot make plans, they cannot go far, and then their friends thin

out, and a few years into nursing someone, their own circle has come down to one person as well. Care narrows two people at once.

And nobody is watching. When nobody comes to the room, there is no one to see what happens there, and the second book had a chapter on giving without a name attached, and here nothing is hidden and still nobody sees it.

◆ Resentment Is Mixed In

If this is left out the chapter is false. The one who stays resents people.

They resent the ones who do not come, they resent the sibling who left it all to them, and sometimes they resent the person lying there. And then they resent themselves for resenting. The double layer from the fifth chapter is thickest here.

Leave the resentment out and the chapter becomes a saintly story. Written as a saintly story, a person who is in that position right now reads it and concludes they are inadequate, and that is the thing this book must least do, so it is recorded. **Staying while resenting is what staying is.**

◆ The Ones Who Did Not Stay

And the ones who left have to be spoken about. This is where the chapter is stuck.

The ones who did not come have reasons. They live far away, they are ill themselves, their children are small, there is no money. Every one of those is true. And from the side of the one who stayed, the reasons are invisible. Only the not coming is visible.

Both are correct. The reasons are a fact and the not coming is a fact. And the two do not reconcile. Many siblings grow apart over it for the rest of their lives,

and both of them are right, and I cannot take a side and have no standing to. The chapter stops here.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Someone stayed to the end of somebody's last few years. Think about how old they were at the time, and what they did with their own work during those years, and the numbers get heavier.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

The order in which people around a sick person thin out is observation and hearsay. I did not count it; I was told it, and it is written as such.

There is material on what happens to families during a long illness. I did not use it. Put numbers in and a person currently in that position starts looking for their own household in the table, and having found

it, it starts to feel like that is what will happen to them. I decided not to write that kind of thing.

11 · Where the Counting Stopped

◆ While You Are Counting There Is an End

One thing kept catching while I wrote these three books. People who count and people who do not are different.

Count and an end arrives eventually. Counting has an end built into it, and while you are keeping track of how much you have done, one day that number passes what can be borne, and passing it, you stop. That is normal and that is what people are.

For people who do not count, that day does not come. There is no number to pass, so nothing is passed. That was what the first chapter could not solve. Why does it continue. **They are not counting, so there is no point at which to end.**

◆ And Nobody Decided to Stop Counting

Here is the odd part. Ask people whose counting has stopped when they decided to stop and no answer comes.

I have not met anyone who decided. They all say that one day they noticed they were not counting. So stopping the counting does not appear to be something you do, and if it could be done by trying there would be a method, and nobody knows one.

This is the limit of this book. That people who stop counting last longer is visible, and the way to stop is not, and if it had been visible I would have written it, and writing it would have made this a book that teaches a method. That it did not become that book is not because I am good. **It is because I could not find the method.**

◆ What Happened Before the Stopping

The people whose counting stopped do have one thing in common. Before it stopped, they saw something.

Many of them had seen what they themselves received. That is the content of the first book, and one day they come to see the things that were already there without ever having been asked for, and after seeing it, they say, the counting went blurry. They cannot explain why and the order is that way. First they see what they received, then the counting thins.

This is my inference, and it seems that once you start counting what you received, that column comes out far larger. Then counting your own giving becomes trivial. It is not that they gave up the arithmetic. The arithmetic stopped balancing and they let go.

◆ There Is Still a Place That Does Not Fit

The place that jammed twice in the second book and again in the eighth chapter jams here too.

There are people who received almost nothing and give a great deal. The ninth chapter said there was often one person beside them. And some of them had no one. I have seen people like that giving enormously.

Then the explanation above does not hold. *They saw what they received and the counting blurred* is an explanation that requires something to have been received. What those people have did not come from anywhere I can find.

◆ Leaving the Place Empty

This place came up four times across the three books. Four times I built an explanation and four times I discarded it.

The reason for discarding was the same each time. If the explanation I built is right, those people get explained and other people stop being explained. A sentence built to explain people that cuts somebody

down is a sentence that must not be used. So all of them went, and I am not building another.

One explanation is missing here. That is the most accurate sentence this book can produce. Leaving a gap as a gap is better than pretending to fill it. The next chapter looks into that gap once and then the book closes.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

Among the people who have done something for you there is one who is not counting it. Ask them and they will say they do not know. That *I do not know* is the most important answer in all three books.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

This chapter is observation and inference throughout. There is not a single number in it, and the things I was told were not counted either. Writing how many

people I met would make it look like a sample, and it is not a sample, so the number is not here.

There may be books on how to stop counting. I did not look. Find one and bring it in and this becomes a chapter introducing a method, and then what the chapter says about not having found one becomes a lie.

12 · So Where Did It Come From

◆ What the Three Books Looked At

Set the three books in a line and it goes like this.

The first looked at the fact that we started out having received. Things never asked for and never paid for had arrived first. The second looked at what was received going sideways. It goes where nothing comes back, and it goes although the arithmetic does not work. The third looked at it not ending. It goes when the other person cannot know, it waits when nothing returns, it stays after the person is gone.

Thirty-six chapters later, one thing is left. **What happened can be confirmed, and why it happens cannot.**

◆ Every Jam Was the Same Jam

I gathered up the places where I got stuck across the three books. Gathered up, they were not different places.

I did not know where the strength to continue at a loss comes from, and I could not explain the people who received nothing and give a great deal. I could not find the reason for sitting for years beside someone who cannot recognize you. I could not find how the counting stops. Four times I built an explanation and four times I discarded it.

The discarded explanations had something in common. All of them looked for the answer **inside the person.** Will, character, reward, circumstance, what was received. Every time I tried to explain it with something inside a person it came up short at some point. And the amount it came up short by was not small.

◆ Is This a Quantity a Person Can Produce

Let me measure one thing here. Whether what is in this book is a quantity a human being can produce.

Giving way ten times is something a person does. A hundred, probably. And going every day for seven years to someone who cannot recognize you. Sending for thirty years to a child who does not answer. Going a whole life toward where absolutely nothing comes back. The quantity does not match what can be explained by human strength.

And people like that are not rare. If they were rare I would call them exceptions. They are common. There is one in every neighborhood, and there was one in nearly every family. **That something inexplicable is extremely common** is the strangest fact I met while writing these three books.

◆ Where Did the Chain Start

Look again at the explanation from the first book. We pass it on because we received, it said. That explanation fits most cases.

Push it backward, though, and it does not end. What I received came from my mother. She received it from her mother. She received it from hers. Keep going and the chain started somewhere, and whoever stood at the start **must have given without having received.**

Giving without having received. The place that jammed four times across three books is standing there at the start of the chain as well, and the same thing has to have happened at the end of the line. So this chain does not look as though it started with people. **What people passed between themselves does not account for the beginning.**

◆ This Is as Far as I Looked

I would like to go further. Go further and it stops being what I saw and becomes what I believe. Write

what you believe as though you saw it and all three of these books collapse, and the eleventh chapter of the second book said an explanation that cannot be argued against is not an explanation, and I will keep that.

So I stop here. What I can write down ends here.

> Sometimes a person gives more than they were given. That much more did not come from a person.

◆ Where This Chapter Came From

This chapter alone has its order changed. The sources come first and Someone Comes to Mind goes after. That box had to be the last box in the book.

Nothing in this chapter was brought in from outside. It stands on what the preceding thirty-five chapters brought.

The near-absence of outside material across these three books was deliberate from the start, and there were several places where a number could have propped something up and all of them came out. What was left out is recorded at the end of each chapter. Few books record what they did not put in, and I think it is the more useful of the two.

And there is one thing I did not write in this chapter. I did not write the answer. Not because I do not have one, but because this is not my place to write it. Written here it becomes my answer, and this is a question the reader has to take as their own. So the question is left and the book closes.

◆ Someone Comes to Mind

One person has kept coming to mind across these three books.

They gave you more than they were given. There was no reason for it. Not because you were good, not

because they had something to collect, not because anybody told them to. They still could not explain it today.

What that person gave you was more than what they had.

> So where did it come from.
